following the end of the Second World War most governments stopped seeing wars of aggression as an appealing tool to advance their interests, and most nations stopped fantasising about conquering and destroying their neighbours. While civil wars and insurgencies have remained commonplace, the post-1945 world has seen a significant decline in full-scale wars between states, and most notably in direct armed conflicts between great powers.[49]

Numerous statistics attest to the decline of war in this post-1945 era, but perhaps the clearest evidence is found in state budgets. For most of recorded history, the military was the number-one item on the budget of every empire, sultanate, kingdom and republic. Governments spent little on health care and education, because most of their resources were consumed by paying soldiers, constructing walls and building warships. When the bureaucrat Chen Xiang examined the annual budget of the Chinese Song dynasty for the year 1065, he found that out of sixty million minqian (currency unit), fifty million (83 per cent) were consumed by the military. Another official, Cai Xiang, wrote, 'If [we] split [all the property] under Heaven into six shares, five shares are spent on the military, and one share is spent on temple offerings and state expenses. How can the country not be poor and the people not in difficulty?'[50]

The same situation prevailed in many other polities, from ancient times to the modern era. The Roman Empire spent about 50–75 per cent of its budget on the military,[51] and the figure was about 60 per cent in the late-seventeenth-century Ottoman Empire.[52] Between 1685 and 1813 the share of the military in British government expenditure averaged 75 per cent.[53] In France, military expenditure between 1630 and 1659 varied between 89 per cent and 93 per cent of the budget, remained above 30 per cent for much of the eighteenth century, and dropped to a low of 25 per cent in 1788 only due to the financial crisis that led to the French Revolution. In Prussia, from 1711 to 1800 the military share of the budget never fell below 75 per cent and occasionally reached as high as 91 per cent.[54] During the relatively peaceful years of 1870–1913, the military ate up an average of 30 per cent of the state budgets of the major powers of Europe, as well as Japan and the United States, while smaller powers like Sweden were spending even more.[55] When war broke out in 1914, military budges skyrocketed. During their involvement in the First World War, French